

BARTHOLOMEW

who has haunted this house
for two hundred years



Print it. Read it together. Then make your own.

This is Bartholomew.



“I have haunted this house,” said Bartholomew,
“for two hundred years.”

Nobody heard him. Nobody ever does.

Nobody else lives here.



Only the cat, who has lived here for eleven years and is not impressed by anything at all.

“It is very quiet,” said Bartholomew. “I like it very much.”

He did not like it very much.

A ghost has one job.



To scare people.

“I am extremely frightening,” said Bartholomew, to the empty room, as he did every night.

He had never scared anybody at all.

So he practised on the cat.



The cat looked at him for a while.
Then the cat looked away.

"A hard crowd," said Bartholomew.

Bartholomew tried again.

Then, one Tuesday, a van.



A mother. A father. Two children.
Seventeen boxes and a lamp.

“Tonight,” said Bartholomew, from the window.
“Tonight I begin.”

First, the terrible moan.

“Two hundred years of practice,” said Bartholomew.



Nobody stirred. The father turned over and muttered something about the pipes.

“The acoustics in this house,” said Bartholomew, “have never been good.”

Bartholomew tried again.

Next, through their bedroom wall.

“They will wake with me already there.”



He meant to arrive beside their bed, all at once.

He got as far as his elbow.

“I am resting,” said Bartholomew, who was stuck, and who stayed there until Thursday.

Then Bartholomew tried again.

Next, the dreadful cold.

"I shall freeze the very air," said Bartholomew.



The family put on their hats.

And their scarves. And their mittens.

"SNOW!" shouted the smallest one. **"INDOORS!"**

"These people," said Bartholomew, "are not normal."

Bartholomew tried again.

Next, appearing suddenly.

"This one never fails," said Bartholomew.



They were facing the other way.

He appeared four more times. They faced the other way four more times.

"That," said Bartholomew, "is entirely their fault."

Bartholomew tried again.

Then he sat down on the stairs.



“Perhaps,” said Bartholomew, very quietly,
“I am not very frightening after all.”

It was the saddest he had been in two hundred years.

Bartholomew did not try again.

And then the cat walked past.



The cat looked straight at him.

The cat had seen him all along.

“Oh,” said Bartholomew.

“Oh. I have been doing them one at a time.”

So he did all four at once.



The squeak. The stuck arm. The snow.

Appearing suddenly, on the landing, at midnight,
all of it, all at the same time.

They jumped so high.



The father dropped the lamp.
The mother said a word she does not usually say.
And then the smallest one laughed, and laughed,
and said, **“Do it again!”**

So he did.



Eleven times before breakfast.

It was the best night Bartholomew had had
in two hundred years.



**“Halloween is coming,”
said the smallest one.**

**“And with you helping us, we can scare
the whole street.”**